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1 draft

1.1 introduction

This teaching statement covers my teaching philosophy, the courses and workshops I've taught at Pratt, mentoring and advising, and future plans.

1.2 teaching philosophy

My teaching philosophy draws from my graduate school training as a literary studies and queer studies scholar. Many of the methods here were developed in my role as a writing instructor for 6 years across three different institutions.

This philosophy is organized into four major themes: (1) close reading as critical and creative practice; (2) writing as thinking; (3) all knowledge as contingent; and (4) active & experiential learning.

1.2.1 1) close reading as critical practice:

The most important skill that I teach in my classes is close reading. Originally developed as an analytical method for literary criticism, close reading is defined as the close and sustained attention to a selection of evidence, such as a passage in a text. It emphasizes the details of the evidence, such as individual words and sentence structure, over the general. While close reading is the analytical methodology par excellence for Literary Studies, as well as other fields the Humanities, its principles apply across different analytical contexts, particularly across my Pratt SI courses, from INFO 601: Foundations to INFO 664: Programming Cultural Heritage.

For example, in my 601: Foundations class, we often use close reading as a tool to guide discussion on a specific reading. I direct students to identify passages that struck them as provocative or confusing, which we then read together as a class. The opportunity to put a single passage on the projector proves generative, giving students the opportunity to dig into details and make new connections in real time. In my 664 class, I take a similar approach. For example, I encourage my students to consider even large datasets at a close distance. I use my own research as an example to model how close attention to language offers material for critique. Last year, I had several students develop 664 projects which customized Small Language Models (SLMs) in order to better study language data up close, with one group of students from my course ended up winning the "People's Choice Award" at the 2026 Info Show.

1.2.2 2) writing as active learning:

Another technique that I often use in courses is writing. This is an active learning technique which I employ through formal writing assignments, which are highly scaffolded papers developed over several weeks, and low-stakes writing exercises, which is a daily practice for organizing thoughts and generating ideas.

In my discussion-based courses, I use free-writing assignments often as a precursor to class discussion. However, I also use free-writing in my programming class, INFO 607: Special Topics (How to Build a Bot), as a tool to help students theorize their final projects. Formal writing assignments, by contrast, are highly scaffolded, with detailed guidance on each step, from drafting research questions, to outlining arguments and evidence, to crafting paragraphs. In my courses that require formal writing assignments, such as 601, INFO: 657, and INFO: 656, I dedicate time across several class meetings to addressing individual aspects of the paper, such as the "hook" of a typical research paper, or the "Discussion" section of a conference paper. This hands-on practice with writing in class is even more important now, with the rise of automated tools which tempt students to offload writing tasks, and therefore the development of critical thinking skills.

1.2.3 3) knowledge as contingent:

I maintain the importance of meeting students where they are by inviting them to use their own life stories and personal interests as a ground for critique and understanding. I also emphasize the importance of perspective,

that all knowledge is contingent and that "infinite vision" as Donna Haraway asserts, "is an illusion, a god trick." Students thus learn the contingency of all knowledge through exposure to a wide range of theoretical points of view and by drawing from their own life experience.

I employ these principles through the selection of readings in my courses, particularly INFO 601, INFO 656, and INFO 657. Readings range from different disciplines and fields, showing how differences in initial questions, assumptions, and approaches will lead to quite different conclusions. For example, in INFO: 657 I assign readings from different fields in the humanities (such as Black Feminist Studies and Archival Studies) so that students have a basis for understanding how the field of Digital Humanities departs from others.

1.3 courses & workshops taught

Courses

- INFO 656: Machine Learning, Fall 2026.
 - This course offers an introduction to machine learning as a practical tool that we can use, and as a technological field with social implications. We will learn about key concepts in machine learning; survey a few key machine learning techniques, such as supervised methods for machine learning (regression and classification), which attempt to map data onto desired outputs, and unsupervised methods (clustering and association), which attempt to find structure within data itself; use openly available tools to implement these techniques on text and image data; learn how to assess the effectiveness of different techniques on particular datasets; and discuss basic issues that confront all machine learning methods.
- INFO 657: Digital Humanities. Spring 2026.
 - This course examines the history, theory, and practice of digital humanities, paying special attention to the ways in which digital humanities are transforming research, disciplines, and even the academy itself. Topics include contrasts and continuities between traditional and digital humanities; tools and techniques used by digital humanists; the processes of planning, funding, managing, and evaluating digital humanities projects; ways in which the digital humanities impact scholarly communication and higher edu-

cation; and the special roles of libraries and information professionals in this growing movement.

- INFO 697: Special Topics - How to Build a Bot. Summer 2025.
 - This course offers a practical introduction to building bots in Python alongside a critical examination of algorithmic bias. Students will learn core programming skills like data collection and API interaction in order to create web crawlers and social media bots. In parallel, students will explore the ethical consequences of automated systems on social platforms, such as the amplification of misinformation and bias that perpetuate social inequalities and discrimination. This course will equip students with the critical perspectives and technical skills to analyze automated systems in a world increasingly shaped by AI and algorithmic decision-making. This course is intended for students interested in both technical development and the social impacts of automation.
- INFO 664: Programming Cultural Heritage. Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Fall 2026.
 - Technical knowledge and proficiency is an increasingly valued and useful skill in a cultural heritage information professional's skillset. This course will introduce and provide a platform for the building up of these abilities. Over the course of the semester the student will become familiar with programming, working with data in a programmatic manner and applying these skills to build a demonstrable project. This course will focus on teaching the basics that will enable an information professional to be successful in today's digital world.
- INFO 601: Foundations of Information. Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Fall 2026.
 - This foundational course focuses on the intersection of people, information, and technology and the theoretical and conceptual foundations of the information field. Students will be introduced to ideas and concepts that will inform future specializations in their course of study and provide them with concrete strategies for ongoing professional growth and development in their area of interest.

Workshops

- Text Processing with Python: Exploring *The Odyssey*. *The Data Storytelling Lab (DSL)*. Fall 2025, Fall 2026.
 - In this hands-on Python workshop, you'll learn the fundamentals of text processing using spaCy (one of the most widely used Python tools for working with text) to study different versions of Homer's epic poem, *The Odyssey*. We will use spaCy to tokenize the different versions of the text, identify persons and places, and compare linguistic patterns across adaptations—allowing us to see the subtle differences in style, characterization, and narrative emphasis across the story's different versions. How does *The Odyssey* change across the major translations? What are the differences between Emily Wilson's version (the one used as the basis for Christopher Nolan's recent feature film) and other major versions of the *Odyssey*? Come and explore the narrative features of the text for yourself.s

1.4 mentoring & advising

In addition to the ~30 students that I teach directly each semester, I currently advise 35 students, mostly in Library and Information Science (LIS), but also a few in Data Analytics and Visualization (DAV), and Information Experience Design (IXD). Each semester, I meet individually with many of these students to discuss their progress in coursework and projects and to strategize their final portfolios, which is the capstone project for the program. I also discuss career expectations and goals with students.

In addition to advising students individually, I also advise two students groups. For one group, *Latines in Tech*, I am the official Faculty Advisor. *Latines in Tech* is professional development group primarily focused on Latinx students. Their main goals are to provide professional development and networking opportunities for their members. The second group, *The Stacks* Student Journal, which is still in the process of obtaining official student group status, is an editorial board comprised of some former students from my 601: Foundations course. These students are currently producing a peer-reviewed journal to showcase their 601 papers. My support for these groups involves attending meetings, participating in their events, and offering guidance as needed.

1.5 future plans

My future plans involve developing two courses:

- First, I plan to develop a Python programming course that is specific to working with text-based data. This course would build off my workshop that I run for the Data Storytelling Lab, which focuses on using advanced tools like the *spaCy* library in Python, which allows users to perform advanced tasks in text cleaning, processing, annotating, and NLP analysis, like Named Entity Recognition. This course would join my other course, INFO 697: How to Build a Bot, to offer instruction in intermediate programming skills.
- Second, I plan to develop a "Readings in Queer Studies" course. While I am aware that theoretically heavy courses have not historically done well in this program, I think attitudes and appetites for this material is shifting. When assigned in my other courses, like INFO: 601 Foundations of Information and INFO: 657 Digital Humanities, readings on Queer Studies generate much interest and discussion, with students often claiming them as their favorite readings from the course. This course would pair well with another Special Topics currently being proposed, "Disability Studies for LIS." To better cater to the LIS student population, whom I believe will be the ones most interested in the course, I would plan to have incorporate direct research in a Queer archive in New York City.

1.6 bank

- active & experiential learning: students practice hands-on with knowledge they bring from experience
 - student investment in material: students must have a stake in what they are learning.
 - meeting the student where they are at: not making assumptions about prior knowledge.